

US History Ch. 21: The Civil Rights Movement, 1954-1968

Origins: Brown and Montgomery

By the early 1950s many states enforced legal racial segregation, and the Supreme Court had long tolerated it under the doctrine of "separate but equal." That began to change with a single case out of Topeka, Kansas. In *Brown v. Board of Education* (1954) the Supreme Court ruled unanimously that separate educational facilities are inherently unequal. The decision overturned the separate but equal doctrine of *Plessy v. Ferguson* (1896) for public schools. It did not, by itself, desegregate a single classroom.

Direct protest against segregation followed close behind. The Montgomery bus boycott began after Rosa Parks was arrested on December 1, 1955, for refusing to give up her seat. Black residents of the city responded by refusing to ride the buses at all. The boycott lasted 381 days and ended after the Supreme Court affirmed that bus segregation was unconstitutional. The victory turned a local protest into a national model for nonviolent resistance and gave a young minister named Martin Luther King Jr. his first national platform.

Resistance to *Brown* came to a head in Little Rock in 1957. Governor Orval Faubus ordered the Arkansas National Guard to block nine Black students from entering Central High School. President Eisenhower responded by sending soldiers of the 101st Airborne Division to escort the students into the school. It was one of the first times the federal government used force to enforce desegregation.

Direct action: sit-ins, Freedom Rides, Birmingham

The movement's next phase moved from the courtroom to the lunch counter. On February 1, 1960, four Black college students sat down at a whites-only Woolworth lunch counter in Greensboro, North Carolina. Within months the sit-ins had spread to more than fifty cities, and the students founded the Student Nonviolent Coordinating Committee (SNCC). The new group would go on to organize much of the direct action that followed.

In 1961, activists tested whether the desegregation of interstate travel was being enforced in practice. The Freedom Riders of 1961 set out to test the Supreme Court ruling that segregation in interstate bus terminals was illegal. The response was often violent. In Anniston, Alabama, a mob firebombed one of the buses and beat the riders as they escaped. Similar attacks met the riders in other cities along their route.

Birmingham, Alabama became the movement's next major battleground in 1963. Commissioner Bull Connor ordered police dogs and fire hoses turned on the marchers, many of them children. Television cameras carried the images across the country. The images shocked the nation, and in June 1963 President Kennedy proposed a sweeping civil rights bill.

Legislation: Washington, the Civil Rights Act, Selma, the Voting Rights Act

The pressure built through 1963 culminated in a mass demonstration in the capital. On August 28, 1963, about 250,000 people gathered at the Lincoln Memorial for the March on Washington for Jobs and Freedom. Martin Luther King Jr. closed the day with the speech remembered as I Have a Dream. The march kept pressure on Congress through the rest of the year.

That pressure produced results the following summer. President Lyndon Johnson signed the Civil Rights Act on July 2, 1964. The act outlawed segregation in public accommodations such as restaurants and hotels and banned employment discrimination. Voting rights, though, still needed a law of their own.

Voting rights came to a crisis point in Selma. On March 7, 1965, state troopers attacked peaceful marchers on the Edmund Pettus Bridge in Selma, a day remembered as Bloody Sunday. The broadcast images pushed Congress to act again. The Voting Rights Act of 1965 banned literacy tests and sent federal registrars to counties that had blocked Black voters. It finally attacked the barriers that had kept the Fifteenth Amendment's promise unfulfilled for generations.

Working with sources

Historians studying this period rely on two broad kinds of evidence. A primary source is created by a participant or witness at the time of the events, such as a letter, a photograph, or a speech. It carries the perspective, and the blind spots, of the person who made it. A secondary source, such as a textbook or a documentary made decades later, interprets primary sources after the fact. Secondary sources are valuable for context but filtered through another author's interpretation.

Reading this chapter's events causally, rather than as an unconnected list of dates, is the harder and more important skill. Again and again, televised violence against nonviolent protesters turned a local campaign into national legislation. Birmingham fed the Civil Rights Act; Selma fed the Voting Rights Act. Taken together, the movement's victories came from court cases, local organizing, and direct action working together, not from any one of them alone.